Dani Girl

By Chris Dimond and Michael Kooman

Suggested Roles:
ACTOR: *Father, Raph (imaginary friend), Darth Cancer, Marty (age 10), Cancer, God*
ACTRESS: *Dani (age 9), Chandrelle, Mother*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

FATHER: **(Pg 13)** Once upon a time. In the Kingdom of Blue Skies

MOTHER: There lived a noble king, King William the Lionheart.

FATHER: With his elegant bride, Queen Katharine, the Compassionate. And one day,

MOTHER: As the sun rose high over their castle . . .

FATHER: They were blessed with a radiant. . .

MOTHER: A beautiful . . .

FATHER: A perfect . . .

BOTH: Daughter . . . And they all lived happily ever after.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *Dani was beautiful -- and they tried so hard to live happily ever after -- but when Dani was diagnosed with childhood leukemia, the whole world changed.*
ACTOR: *Before she was even 5 years old, Dani created an imaginary friend, Raph, to help her through the procedures, the sickness, the grief, and the pain.*
ACTRESS: *See, Raph is short for St. Raphael, the patron saint of healing. Dani and her mom fought the cancer head on and won; and for three glorious years, Dani was cancer free. But then . . .*
TOGETHER: *Dani Girl by Chris Dimond and Michael Kooman.*

DANI: **(Pg 14)** It's back again, isn't it? *(beat)* **(Pg 15-20)** I thought I was done.

RAPH: Hey, kid. It's not the end of the world.

DANI: I hate this place, Raph. It reeks of disease.

RAPH: Think of the games we can play. *(becomes flamboyant French hairdresser RAPHAEL)*

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RAPHAEL: ***Bonjour!*** Et welcome to Raphael's Spa de Beauty. Oh la la. Zis must be mademoiselle Danica, ze most ***belle femme*** in ze world.

DANI: Well, perhaps one game.

RAPHAEL: ***Bonne. Zut alors!*** What is zis collection de stringy fungus on top of your 'ead?

DANI: My hair? I like my hair.

RAPHAEL: ***Mais non****.* Zis will not do at all. But, never fear, ***mademoiselle****.* Nozing is too great a miracle for Raphael, 'airdresser to ze stars. *(He shaves her head.)* ***Sacre bleu. C'est magnifique.***

DANI: What? Let me see.

RAPHAEL: *(hands her a mirror)* ***C'est belle, non?***

DANI: *(sees herself and reacts)* No. No.

RAPHAEL: It say beauty. It say strength.

DANI: It says sick. I don't want to play anymore!

RAPH: Kid, there are some games you can't exactly quit.

DANI: Give me my hair back.

RAPH: That's not the way it works. *(pause)* You know how this goes. *(pause)* Alright. Fine. You win. New game. *(becomes WINK WINKENDALE, a game show host)*

WINK. Good evening, ladies and gentlemen. I'm Wink Winkendale, and this is Trivial Pursuit . . . of Death. Our first contestant. All the way from pediatric oncology, Danica Lyons. *(Danica waves to the studio audience and takes her position)* Now Danica, here's how our game works: I'm going to ask you the questions on this card. If you can answer correctly . . . Tell her what she wins, Chandrelle.

CHANDRELLE. Her hair, Wink. She's playing for her hair.

WINK. And if she loses?

CHANDRELLE. It's gonna be a long and drawn-out treatment period full of pain and suffering, followed by almost certain death.

WINK. Alright, our first category is geography. Are you ready, Danica?

DANI: I suppose so.

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WINK. Your question is . . . which constellation is named for the Latin word for crab?

DANI: Cancer?

WINK. Correct! Next question . . . Osteosarcoma and medulloblastoma are types of what disease?

DANI: Cancer.

WINK. Correct again. Only one question stands between you and your hair. Are you ready?

DANI: Yes, I am, Wink.

WINK. For a lifetime supply of your own hair. Your question is . . . why is cancer?

DANI: What? That's not fair.

WINK. Why is cancer?

DANI: I . . . I don't know.

WINK. Ooh. I'm sorry, that is incorrect. "I don't know" is not **why** cancer is.

DANI: Raph! It's not even a real question.

RAPH: Hey, how are you supposed to get rid of something when you don't know why it's there?

DANI: But I don't know.

RAPH: Then I guess you'd better find out.

TRANSITION

ACTRESS: *The next day Raph takes a back seat to a new friend: Marty Merriweather is moved into Dani's room in the pediatric oncology ward, and they talk late into the night. Maybe Marty would know the answer to the question: "Why is Cancer?"*

MARTY: **(Pg 28-29)** I vomited nine times last night. It was orange.

DANI: So? Big deal. One night I threw up ten times. And it was green with little purple chunks. *(pause)* Look, what kind of cancer do you have anyways?

MARTY: Hodgkin's.

DANI: Oh, please. Hodgkin's is a sissy cancer. I'm going to find out why cancer is and then everything will be back to normal. Once I figure out why it is I'll get my hair back.

MARTY: That doesn't make sense.

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DANI: But it's true. You're just jealous because I'm going to get my hair back and you'll still be looking all Captain Kirk.

MARTY: It's Picard. Picard is bald. Captain Kirk has a bountiful head of hair. **(Pg 37)** Do you think this getting your hair back thing would work for me too?

DANI: Probably.

MARTY: Cause I think I know why cancer is. I think you must've done something to deserve it.

DANI: Merriweather, there is no evidence to suggest –

MARTY: Yuh-huh. Cause I broke the bishop in my father's chess set and then I had to come into the hospital . . . What did you do?

DANI: I don't know. I'm fairly certain I'm perfect.

*****

BOTH: **(Pg 37-38)** Once upon a time.

FATHER: In the Kingdom of Blue Skies.

MOTHER: There lived a noble king.

FATHER: And a compassionate queen. They were blessed with a fearless...

MOTHER: A beautiful...

FATHER: A perfect - *(He turns away)* My Queen, I must leave you and the princess.

MOTHER: What? What are you talking about, Will? You cannot do this to us.

FATHER: Tell her I went on a long journey, to a land far away.

MOTHER: And when she's old enough to ask why?

FATHER: M'lady, by then she will know the truth. What other reason could there be?

***** **Dream Sequences*****

(Darth Cancer appears – Words in all CAPS are spoken in the evil voice of Darth Vader)

DARTH CANCER: **(Pg 47-48)** AND SO WE MEET AGAIN, DANICAN

DANI: Cancer.

DARTH CANCER: That's Darth Cancer to you. THERE WILL BE NO ESCAPE THIS TIME.

DANI: I'll teach you to stand between a girl and her hair. *(She unleashes her light saber; He*

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does the same. They fight)

DARTH CANCER: YOU'LL NEVER WIN FOOLISH CHILD. DON'T YOU REALIZE I'M INSIDE? SEARCH YOUR FEELINGS, IT'S THE TRUTH. Your mother never told you the truth about your father. She never told you why he left.

DANI: He went on a long journey, to a land far, far away.

DARTH CANCER: THAT IS WHAT SHE'D HAVE YOU BELIEVE. BUT YOU KNOW WHAT MADE HIM LEAVE. YOUR FATHER LEFT BECAUSE OF YOU.

DANI: No! *(She charges passionately)*

DARTH CANCER: *(knocks her to the ground)* Now, feel the true power of the dark side. *(He stretches out his hand.*

DANI: *(coughs violently and the dream changes again, back to her father)*

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FATHER: **(Pg 56)** *(throughout this speech, Dani reacts in her sleep . . . murmuring "no," shaking her head, crying, etc)* Once upon a time there lived a noble king and a compassionate queen. They lived happily in their blue-sky kingdom. Until one day, along came a princess. Seemingly perfect, the princess was cursed. Before their eyes the beautiful baby transformed into a hideous monster! *(DANI opens her mouth, but no sound comes out)* The monster banished the king and left the queen a shadow of herself. No one lived happy ever after, because no matter how she tried, the princess could never, ever set things right!

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DANI: *(DANI wakes with a start and gasps for breath.)* Noooo! **(Pg 64)** It's all my fault.

CANCER POSING AS RAPH: **(Pg 68)** Why don't we play a game? It would make all of your pain go away. Forever.

DANI: What is it?

CANCER POSING AS RAPH: *(singing)* BLUE COTTON CANDY SKIES. / FUNNEL CAKES, ICE CREAM CONES, CURLY FRIES. / THE MUSIC OF CHILDREN'S MELODIC SQUEALS, / GIGANTIC MAGICAL FERRIS WHEELS. IN COMALAND! *

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DANI: Comaland?

CANCER POSING AS RAPH: Yeah, Comaland. It's like Disneyland. But not.

DANI: **(Pg 69)** Will I need needles, or shots or pills?

CANCER POSING AS RAPH: Not in Comaland.

DANI: Okay. I'll play.

CANCER POSING AS RAPH: *(turning evil and abrasive)* Shut your mouth.

DANI: What did you say?

CANCER POSING AS RAPH: *(mocking)* What did you say?

DANI: You're not Raph! Cancer! What have you done with Raph?

CANCER: What do you think?

DANI: You killed him? You killed Raph! *(tries to attack but is unable to move)*

CANCER: You can't win now, stupid. You're in a coma. *(laughs maniacally and exits)*

DANI: Wait! You can't . . . you can't . . .

*****

DANI: **(Pg 71-75)** *(wakes up abruptly. GOD enters.)* Who are you? God?

GOD: Sometimes, Dani, you just have to believe.

DANI: *(thinking)* God? Why is cancer? I'm sorry, but it's urgent.

GOD: I don't have an answer for you, Dani. What I know is this: Everything exists. Good and bad, courage and fear, joy and pain. They all **are**. Trouble is, they sometimes get all mixed up in the same wrapper.

DANI: But, why?

GOD: Just because things are, doesn't mean they have a knowable reason. Why is love, Dani? Why is candy?

DANI: **. . .**Then . . . all the hospitals, and the treatments, everything . . . it's all for nothing. *(long pause)* I don't want to die.

GOD: I know you don't. But death is another one of those things that just. . . **is**.

DANI: But you're God. Can't you just take the cancer out of my life completely?

GOD: I could. Like it never happened. But, if I do, you'll lose everything that came with it.

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DANI: I think I'd be okay with that.

GOD: Are you sure? Not everybody spends life living, Dani. You have.

DANI: Yeah, but not because of cancer.

GOD: What do you think sparked your incredible imagination?

DANI: Really? *(beat)* I don't think [it's] quite worth cancer.

GOD: Then I guess you're right. It was all for nothing. I can give you life without cancer. It just won't be this one. But, if that's what you want . . .

DANI: Wait. Will I get to see my mom?

GOD: Anytime you want. *(long pause while she comes to terms with death)*

DANI: I'm ready. *(holds ups her arms as if bathing in a white light)*

GOD: The world is cruel . . . unfair. But hope lives everywhere. Beneath the grief and despair. Now pain shall cease.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2014 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier – MS
2017 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier – MS
2021 National Qualifier
2023 National Qualifier – MS
2024 National Qualifier – MS
2025 National Qualifier – MS
NIETOC
CA State Qualifier
CO State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

Music and Lyrics for Comaland can be found here:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=J_umjsbEMvc

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